

"Hell, I've already seen a statue!" one of the men snorted.

"Let's go to a night club instead!"

The other man agreed enthusiastically. The wives capitulated, and I, being the host, submitted to the inevitable with as much grace as possible under the circumstances. As a consequence, we all spent the evening in an airless, smoke-filled cabaret exactly like every other airless, smoke-filled cabaret anywhere in the world, listening to a fourth-rate jazz band blare out background noise for a fifth-rate floor show.

Now, I have nothing against cabarets, jazz bands or floor-shows. I enjoy all three—provided they're good and provided I don't have to live on a steady diet of them. But I certainly can't understand why so many Americans will travel thousands of miles to a world cultural center such as Paris and then spend their time night clubbing.

Countless experiences similar to these I've related have led me to believe that a comparison between modern American men and the educated barbarians of ancient

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Rome is not so terribly far-fetched after all. I've found that the majority of American men really believe there is something effeminate— if not downright subversively un-American—about showing any interest in literature, drama, art, classical music, opera, ballet or any other type of cultural endeavor. It is virtually their *hubris* that they are too "manly" and "virile" for such effete things, that they prefer basketball to Bach or Brueghel and poker to Plato or Pirandello.

Unfortunately, this culture phobia is not an aberration peculiar to the uneducated clods in our society. It is to be found in virulent forms even among highly successful and otherwise intelligent and well-educated individuals. I've heard more than one man with a Phi Beta Kappa key glittering on his watch chain proclaim loudly that he